CAPITAL MOVE



Buoyed by the victories in the recent municipal polls, Telangana CM **Revanth Reddy** took his cabinet to Delhi for a review meeting with the Congress leadership. The Opposition Bharat Rashtra Samithi was livid, with Siddipet MLA and nephew of ex-CM K. Chandrasekhara Rao (KCR), T. Harish Rao, accusing Reddy of "mortgaging Telangana's self-respect" at the Dilli durbar. The sharpest response, though, came from KCR's estranged daughter and former MP K. Kavitha. She agreed the criticism was valid, noting that, earlier, such meetings were held at Erravelli (KCR's farmhouse), but now they had shifted to Delhi!

Pure Bread



Already facing one prohibition, Bihar now looks set for more. On February 22, deputy CM **Vijay Kumar Sinha** announced a ban on sale of meat and fish near schools, religious institutions and crowded places, citing public concerns over "public health, social harmony" and, bizarrely, the "prevention of violent tendencies among children". He's warned that "unlicensed and unhygienic" roadside stalls will not be spared, which could affect the huge number of informal vendors in Bihar. Critics are up in arms, but Sinha is firm, saying "spirit of purity" must be maintained.

'UNITED' FRONT



In a display of inspired political timing, Uttar Pradesh governor and ex-Gujarat CM **Anandiben Patel** has urged Kadva and Leuva Patidars to unite under a broader Patidar identity. The appeal comes as her daughter, Anar, takes charge of the Shri Khodaldham Trust, the most influential religious and socio-political body of the Leuva Patidars. Her critics say it also revives memories of the 2016 Patidar agitation for 'quotas' that cost Anandiben the CM's job.

Kaushik Deka with Anilesh S. Mahajan, Avaneesh Mishra, Prasad Nichenametla, Amitabh Srivastava and Jumana Shah

ECO WATCH

GUJARAT'S BIRD CENSUS
CHIRPING AWAY

By **Jumana Shah**

Gujarat's latest biennial bird census across four major wetlands and other sites is atwitter with good news—the avian count has increased by 24 per cent, from 833,000 in 2024 to 1.03 million in 2026. The biggest gain was recorded in Nal Sarovar, where the population has increased by a staggering 56 per cent—from 412,000 in 2023-24 to 642,000 in 2024-25. Thol has also seen its strongest numbers in 15 years, 74,400 birds. The numbers are heartening as both wetlands are located on the fringes of Ahmedabad city's urban sprawl.

The rise is attributed to the ban on boating in the Nal after a boat capsize incident in Vadodara's Hari river in 2024 killed 14 people. Also, rainfall in the state has been higher than the region's long-term average by 25 per cent (attributed to climate change).

In other news, the data reveals migratory flamingoes have ditched the inland wetland sanctuaries and are prioritising the Great Rann of Kutch (GRK). Kutch is the largest flamingo breeding site in Asia.

Gujarat, with its coastal mudflats and isolated saltpans in the great desert expanse of the GRK and several other inland wetlands, is a key part of the Central Asian Flyway (CAF) of migratory birds. The CAF covers 30 countries and supports millions of birds that travel thousands of kilometres between breeding and wintering grounds. Meanwhile, a reality check: this year, only 270 species of birds were registered, down from 329 in the last census.

